

PREMISE DELTA v0.1 · THE TRUST VERSION ·

2026-09-05

Stephen's concept, 2026-09-05: Violet did not suspect her four friends; they were the only people she trusted. She left the keys and the letters so that, if anything happened to her, the four could put the pieces together and, if there was anything, take it to the police. Only when they work it together do they find the evidence pointing at one of themselves. This document states the change against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 (with the v1.5 and v1.6 amendments), sketches the three letters under it, closes the holes it opens, lists what it changes and what it does not, and ends with the attack prompt. Nothing here is ruled. A premise change counts as attacked only when a result file exists beside this one.

1. The device, before and after

Before (premise v8.1, ruled and closed to attack). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter says: I think one of you is planning to kill me, I don't know which, I might be wrong, not the police, what I found is behind this door. The second letter, from behind the door, says: I know. The second letter is Brad's forgery; the first is hers. The episode's central tell (chapter 7) is the certainty gap: dead women don't get surer.

After (this delta). A dead woman's trust is weaponised by one of the four she trusted. Her key letter says: you four are the only people I trust, which is why you each have a key; two things have happened that I can't explain and can't prove; they are written down behind this door with the thing I found; open it together and you will know what to do. The second letter, from behind the door, says: I trusted you four and I was wrong about one of you; I know. The second letter is Brad's forgery; the first is hers. The episode's central tell (chapter 7) becomes the trust gap: a woman who wrote "you are the only people I trust" did not, the same week, write "one of you".

Everything downstream of the second letter is unchanged: the room works the forgery, it lands on Liam, Margo holds the money fact and her silence, Brad vanishes, Margo dies, the survivors accuse each other, the police look and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. The three letters, sketched (not prose; Fable writes prose)

The key letter (genuine, four identical copies, posted after the funeral). If you've got this, I'm dead. You four are the only people I trust, which is why each of you has a key. Two things happened this autumn that I can't explain and can't prove, and I'm not going to embarrass myself over them while I'm alive. If I'm dead and it wasn't my stairs or my heart, they matter. I've written them down and put them behind the door of my locker at the boatsheds by the slip, with the thing I found. New padlock. These four keys are the only ones. Open it together, all four of you, read it together, and you'll know what to do. It's probably nothing. Violet.

No suspicion. No police instruction either way. "You'll know what to do" is deliberate: it leaves the police to their judgement, which is what Brad's forgery then takes away.

The locker letter (genuine; only Brad ever reads it; ash on Day 17). The tin: the two a day she lies about, the tin under the stairs with the paints and the garden concentrates, the stain through the paper, not lit,

the loose lid, the capped bottle on the shelf above, "could be me, and I don't believe it". The panel: the leak, the ceiling board, a panel in the roof above her own racks, her own alphabet, the one she teaches, done better than she has ever done it, gilded, signed with a mark that is not a name. She asked Brad first, because he is the other signwriter and the one she trusts on hands, and he did not know it; then the café, the cinema, two other signwriters; nobody knew the hand. She has told none of them about the tin because she would have to admit the cigarettes and because it may be her own carelessness. Then the instruction: if I'm dead and it wasn't an accident, someone has been in my house, and someone with my key; each of you write down everything odd you know about the other three from this year, however small, and read the four lists at one table; then, and only then, the police, with something in your hands. "I think it's in the pieces." Be careful. Write legibly.

Note what this letter does that the old one could not: it names Brad as the person she asked. He reads that on Day 16, and burns it.

The locker letter (forged; what the four read on Day 19). Her shape, her paper, her pen, her hand. Opens on the turn: I trusted you four. I was wrong about one of you. I know now. Then the claims, every one leaning the same way and none naming a person: one of you owns a third of the boatyard and lets the town think otherwise; one of you told me the day the papers were signed how it was paid for; one of you gave me the board in my hall that day; the money in my tin came from one of you, every quarter since, for saying nothing; a third claim to be set with the forgery rebuild. Then the instruction he needs: don't go to the police; I can prove nothing, they'd find nothing, and he would know you had been. One kind line about the youngest, in passing. Read this together, and be careful. Violet.

The forgery carries the accusation, the certainty and the police ban. All three are his.

3. The holes this opens, and how they close

Hole 1. A woman who trusts four friends and is worried tells them over dinner. Why letters for after her death? Character, and it is already in the five. She is funny in a way that costs; she lies about cigarettes with total confidence; she will not be the woman who calls four friends round to say her tobacco went off and there is a very good alphabet in her roof. She thinks she is probably being silly. The tin may be her own carelessness. The panel is odd, not sinister, on its own. So she does what a practical person does with a worry she cannot justify: she writes it down, locks it up, gives the keys to the people she would want to read it, and gets on. The letter says so: "I'm not going to embarrass myself over them while I'm alive" and "it's probably nothing". Her refusal to go to the police is no longer fear of tipping the killer; it is the ordinary refusal to look mad over a tin. Sweep row C1 restated; the outcome is the same (any route ends at Del's desk with a note and nothing).

Hole 2. A woman who trusts Brad asks Brad about the hand first. She does, on about Day minus 70, the week she finds it. He says he does not know it. This accelerates Brad: in the current spine he learns she is asking round on Day minus 40 from the café; here he is asked to his face on Day minus 70 and lies. Sweep row C2 re-runs from minus 70: he has five more weeks and he uses them the same way (the tin on minus 38, the money demand on minus 110 is already behind him, the stairs on Day 0). Nothing in his coherence changes; if anything the lie to her face is the moment his plan hardens. Her letter records that she asked him, which is why the letter had to burn: it is the one document that puts the panel in front of Brad's eyes before her death.

Hole 3. If her letter tells them to go to the police, the room walks in on Day 19 with the forged letter, a tampering canvass finds the boat owner who saw Brad at the locker on the Wednesday, and the spine collapses by Day 30. Her key letter gives no police instruction at all ("you'll

know what to do"). The police ban is Brad's, in the forgery, with a reason the room accepts because it is frightened. Sweep rows C4 (Ruby) and C5 (Margo) are unchanged in outcome: Ruby's professional duty test still finds no living person at risk; Margo's silence is still hers. Del, if handed the key letter alone on Day 14: a dead woman trusted her friends and was worried about something she could not prove; note.

Hole 4. Does the room swallow "I trust you all" followed by "one of you"? More easily than it swallowed "I think" followed by "I know", because the room reads the second letter as later knowledge: she trusted them when she wrote the first, then found out. Nobody in the room knows both were written the same week; the solicitor's slip dates only the lodging of the key letters. That is exactly the fact Ally puts beside the two letters in chapter 7, and it is a bigger contradiction than the old one.

Hole 5. The tin is a secret from the four, so why is the smoking a confidence they share? The five says she lied about the cigarettes with total confidence. The four know and she still denies it; a running joke, which is why nobody but the four could know where the tin lives, and why she cannot mention the tin without conceding the joke. That stands under both versions.

4. What changes in ruled and built artefacts

Artefact	Change
Premise v8.1	The device (section 1). Stephen's document.
Cold open v0.4 (reader-checked)	The middle: "according to the letter, one of them may have been planning to kill her. Violet didn't know which one. She admitted she might be wrong. But she was frightened enough to leave behind four keys. She also told her friends not to go to the police. Instead, she directed them to a locked door. Behind it, she said, was the reason she had become afraid." becomes the trust statement and the locked door; and "This one didn't say she thought. It said she knew." becomes the turn from trust to accusation. Sentence-level re-check by the three readers.
Structure v2.2, chapter 1	The accusation moves from p01_04's completion to p01_06's. p01_04 becomes the four named and her trust in them (a softer beat); p01_06 carries the turn. F3 (first tap) unaffected. F4 seams re-ruled for packages 3 to 6.
Chapter 1 build (12 packages, played and signed off)	Beat graphs for packages 4, 5 and 6 rewritten; two lines ruled on 2026-09-03 fall with them. No VO recorded. About one day.
Key letter (ruled 2026-09-05)	Void; rewritten as section 2.
Chapter 2 prose (drafted)	Package 2 (the key letter as object) and package 3 (the room, D1) redrafted; the D1 choice itself unchanged.
Spine	C1 rows restated (routes and reasons); C2 from minus 70; ledger 17 (her belief); B3 rows 25, 28, 30; D3 claims table; A1 minus 70.
Chapter 7	The tell restated as the trust gap. Stronger, no other change.

5. What does not change

The motive (the money). The panel (her alphabet, his mark) and the tin. Margo's six-week silence, the load-bearing lock. Brad's vanish, Margo's death, the survivors' fear, the police look, the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions and their branches. The arrest under the deckhand's name. The season notch. The title.

6. Cost

About one day of content and structure work, one reader sitting for the changed open, and this attack. No recorded VO is lost.

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. A premise change has been proposed. Your job is to break it, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full, then attack on five fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **Violet's behaviour.** Would a fit, sharp, practical forty-four-year-old who trusts four friends write sealed letters for after her death rather than talk to them, and would she ask exactly one of them (the other signwriter) about the panel and no one about the tin? Attack the "probably nothing, won't embarrass myself" reason.
2. **The forged letter's load.** Under the delta, the accusation, the certainty and the police ban are all Brad's. Does the room believe a second letter that reverses the first so completely? Find the question one of the four would ask on Day 19 that the delta has not answered.
3. **The police route.** Her key letter gives no instruction about the police. Does the absence of an instruction send the four to the police anyway, before the locker is opened (Days 14 to 19), and what happens if it does? Is "you'll know what to do" a wall dressed as freedom?
4. **The reader.** The current cold open lands "one of them may have been planning to kill her" inside the first minute and testers rated it strongly. Does replacing suspicion with trust at that point lose the hook, delay it to the second letter, or sharpen it? Say which, and why a listener would keep listening through the trust paragraph.
5. **The chapter 7 tell.** Is "she trusted them, then accused them" a better contradiction than "she thought, then she knew", or a worse one because it is too loud too early? Would an ordinary player notice it in chapter 2 and feel that the four are fools for not noticing?

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.